Chapter 5

The Ostrich and the Tortoise

SUMMARY. Tortoise and Ostrich were arguing. Tortoise told Ostrich, "If I cook myself, you'll eat me." Ostrich said he would never do that. But Tortoise fooled him into eating from a pot of cooked tortoise eggs. When he learned what he had done, Ostrich vomited, kicked the pot, and has had red, split shins ever since.

SPEAKER. *N!ani |'Kun*

RECORDED. Tsumkwe, Namibia, 2006

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‡'ang ‖'a ha ‡'angan
the thought that he was thinking
g‡haan ha ‖o'a sa ha dsuu
long ago the tortoise and the ostrich
ha ‖o'a sa dsuu n‡uian khoe
the tortoise and the ostrich were arguing
te ha ‖o'a !oa dsuu te ko: "a-o,
and the tortoise told the ostrich and said, "you,
otca ka mi g|ae ‖ohm mi |'ae he n|oan mi |'ae okaa a g|ae 'm mi "
if i go chop myself up and cook myself you'll go and eat me "
te ha ko "maooooooooooooooooo
and he said "(exclamation meaning yow)
mia puh koh
ostrich speech meaning I will never do it
mi cin puh koh"
I will never do it"

ha ko, "N!au, mi g|ae du mi |'ae ka a g|ae 'm mi"
he said, "Man, I'm gonna go fix myself and you're gonna come and eat me "
ha ko "ha se" te kahin ha g|ae ǁohm !hara ha !on!'usi
he said "you'll see" and therefore he went and split his shins
ce du ǁu kxo ka ha, ha ǁo'a ǂ'aun 'm
go put the pot on the fire again so he, the tortoise must eat
!xau, "|u 'm a"
(he) rejected (that, saying) "(I'll) never eat you"
te ha kua tsau te
and he immediately got up and
!a'ami te kua sin g|ae n!un te ǁu ǁ'a kxo-a
immediately ran in a circle and just went to stand and put that pot on the fire
kua ka ha n!usi ha kua du
quickly cooked his eggs
ka sa to'a g!an-g!an kahin ke, ǁ'aka sa
those red red ones that are here, those
ha g|ae te ka toan
he came and they were ready
ǁua ka te g|ae ku ko ka ha
set the pot on the fire and went and did and then he
ha ka, ka ku n!om te ha
he then, it was cooking and he
ku haq'are g!u te tsi g|ae se
went to fetch water and came back and saw
ǁu ka
the pot sitting on the fire
te n!un
and stood
khuin ka ha ooa
like this while he was doing
te g|ae n|angan
and went
ǁ'ai din n!a'aaaaaaaaaaan
a bi-i-ig clump of grass (??)
khama ha (?) ha ka !xui te ka ko !uih nǂhao
because he (?)...and it fell scattering
ha ge ku se
he stood and looked
ko, "jua ǁu kxoa ke kah?"
said, "who put this pot on?"
n!aesi gǁa
all was still

”ha ne ǁu kxoa ke?”
”who put this pot on?”
n!aesi gǁa. ”ha nǁa jua ǁu k xoa ke”
all was still. ”tell me the person who put this pot on”
n!aesi gǁa. ” ye,
all was still. ”hey,
gǁxun !aro n|ang tci jaan ke he
(let me) put down my yoke and this good thing here
mi ’m tshan
I’ll taste
ka tshan kahin ka ke mi ku ko mi ku tshan ka tci”
and taste this stuff here, I say I will taste the thing”
ha te ku tshan
he tasted it
te gu te
and took it and
ko kho n‡au !ha
was eating the meat from the bone
|oa o ooa te o ka n|a’ngsi te ha ko: ”ho,
didn’t (?) and he said ”ho,
mi hin ku ‡hoe a ka n!anga a ko tzi ka ’m a
I here will take you from the fire and set you aside and eat you
‡hoe na, mi te ’m
take it off the fire for me, I’m going to eat
toan ka te tchi toan ka te !ae ka te tchi”
it all up and drink (the fat) all up and carry it on my shoulders and drink (the fat)”
ha ko ”tsxantsxan” ko ǁ’a ǁ’aia te ko: ”a re koh ko hatce?
he said ”tsxantsxan” (not clear) and said ”what did you say?
ha nǁa, ha, ha koh ko a te |u ’m mi
tell me, you, you had said that you would not eat me
kaa ne re a ka ku ’m mi re o hatce?”
what is it that now you’re eating me?”
te ha ko ”waq, waq, waq,” ko ”hatcece khoe?” te
and he said ”waq, waq, waq, said ”what is this?” and
tshu tse(tzi?) koara te ha g|ae !aah
vomited (?) and he ran off
kua !oa ha ko ha hin ke g|ae du ke
soon told him saying he would go and
ǁohm !hara ha !on!’usi te du te
chop-split his shins and
ǁu ǁ’a kxoa te ǁ’ahaa koe ǁama te tsi g|ae ko: ”yao,
put that pot on and then he came and arrived and said ”yow,

ka jia ke kaqe o hatce?" !aih tcaq
what shit is this here?" kicked-spilled
g|ae tcaqa ka ku tcaq ka
went and spilled it, spilled it
"yao, aa ni 'm mi, a kah koh..."
"yow, are you going to eat me, you long ago..."
"tcaua, tca mi ku ǁaea a.
(emphatically) "no, I'm holding it for you.
mia |u 'm a."
I won't eat you."